

you feel safe? It sounds like the bleeding obvious, but you'd be surprised how often first home buyers don't do a basic test-run of what it would be like to function day-to-day in that property.

2. A house on land, irrespective of city access

Must have: Any house you can get your hands on!

Why? Land provides the greatest price growth.

'I believe in the supply and demand of land being the main price driver more than anything else, and you have a lot of people who don't need to work in the city,' Unkles says.

Cassandra Browne, one of my oldest friends who I met at university, has moved her life to the country and spends as much on her mortgage as I used to on shoes. Her employment as a social worker was taking her further and further out of the CBD, so she and her husband bought a farmhouse and relocated 90 minutes out of the city. As worker bees endure the peak-hour drive in and out of town, Cassandra is cruising the highway in the opposite direction. No more time-sucking traffic snarls or the pinch of a stressful mortgage. 'Mentally, it is easy to see property prices rising and think, "It's impossible, what's the point?"' she says. 'If you do nothing and spend all your cash, in five years you'll be wishing you started today.'

How to find this kind of property

Start at your dream location and work outwards to find the so-called bridesmaid suburb that you can afford. This requires more time than almost any other search. You need to discover your needle in a haystack.

Do this by making your own hot-zone map. Print a suburb map of your city and pinpoint where you would really love to live. Dream big and work backwards, in order to find a compromise that makes you happy. Research the house prices in those postcodes, by sourcing:

- Properties sold within your budget – allowing up to a \$50,000 buffer for prices to move up, or increase due to buyer competition, at least a little – and with your desired attributes, be it two bedrooms, off-street